

Counselor Educator Interview

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Author Note

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I have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

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Interview Summary

As a future counselor educator, learning from those experienced in the field is important. Ignoring the lessons learned from current and past educators is to ignore hard-earned wisdom. With this in mind, I asked a current local counselor educator to meet with me and have a conversation about his hard-earned wisdom. The approach to this conversational interview was informal and relational. We met at a restaurant after I briefly informed him of the nature and purpose of the meeting over email. When we met, having been his student in the past, we caught up on family and life. I then made explicit the dilemma of one counselor interviewing another counselor. I wanted to let the interviewee relax and know that I was comfortable having him as the center of the conversation. In fact, I needed him to be this time.

Once we formally began the interview process, I began with a summary of the questions that I had to ask him. I delineated that the heart of the discussion was for me to gain insight into my own path forward with teaching. I asked a general question about how he began his journey as a counselor, and he answered with educational experience, professional experience, and teaching experience. Trying to remain relational and informal, I looked for an opportunity to shift the conversation from question to question. We discussed the interviewee's roles, his teaching philosophy, how he integrated multicultural competency into his educational process, and his concerns for the future of the field.

Once these questions were addressed, we wrapped up our conversation with best wishes and a professional exchange before relating our weekend plans and future hopes. This conversation gave me insights and an understanding of my future role as a counselor educator.

Personal and Professional Reactions

Like most of my career and educational path, this course and this conversation have been about making it my own. One often has a prejudiced narrative when looking ahead or starting out to complete a goal. What it would be like for me (as a fifty-five-year-old white man who has spent most of his life learning that he can do hard things) to become a counselor educator has been no different. When I met with my colleague to hear his perspective on the matter, I had two absolute ideas. One, I must be employed full-time as an educator to make an impact on the world of counseling. Two, I must be an educator at an institution focused on cutting-edge research to make an impact on counseling psychology. Neither of these ideas proved to be absolute truth after our conversation, however.

Personally, I learned that I can make an impact on emerging counselors in more ways than one. And, the fact of the matter is, I already am. Introspection on our talk has allowed me to revise my narrative to include the possibility that supervising students and new licensees, directing a counseling agency, continuing in my role as a staff counselor at a church, teaching in venues not necessarily associated with graduate counseling, and options I have not even dreamed of yet are all ways I am and will make an impact on the world of counseling.

Professionally, I learned that research and dissemination can and should take on many forms and is valuable in all of them. Hearing my interviewee relate that his scholarship has been in the form of journal articles relating to the more pragmatic side of counselor education and counseling gave me the freedom to explore the idea of writing with others on their research and writing meta-research articles or qualitative designs. I do not have to be employed full-time by a research-driven institution to make an impact on counseling psychology, although that may

happen. This introspective conversation has also mostly aligned with what I have learned in this course about being a counselor educator.

Alignment with Previous Knowledge

From the beginning of this course and the assigned reading (particularly Svinicki and McKeachie, 2014, page 4), I have been confronted with the big picture idea that one's philosophy and style of teaching should fit with the university culture for maximum impact and educator satisfaction. The conversation I had with this counselor educator confirmed that wise counsel. Asking how he became a counselor educator and how he came to his current institution showed the significance of culture and fitment into an institution. I have some soul-searching to do on this topic, but it does indicate the need to select a school wisely when searching for an open position. Just because the door is open doesn't mean I should walk through it.

Our talk also confirmed the idea that good counselors make good educators make good mentors make good supervisors. That is, we are taught the skills necessary for building relationships early in our own counselor education and we should not be shy about employing those skills as counselor educators. Chapter ten of West et al. (2013) aligns with my view and my interviewee's view that building relationships should be organic and intentional at the same time. He does not mentor students on scholarly pursuits but does unconventional mentoring in pre-marital counseling, advising, professional identity, and life coaching. Though these relationships are mostly student-sought, their depth and import of them are no less weighty. West et al. (2013, p. 167) also emphasize the personhood of the student. My conversation with this counselor educator did this idea justice. Perhaps it is even why I chose this educator to interview at the outset. I knew he would appreciate the *people* he was teaching and the *person* he was helping grow with the conversation at hand.

Biblical Worldview

I have two lenses for my approach to counseling. These two lenses allow me to prioritize my biblical worldview while emphasizing my understanding of counseling psychology. When using binoculars, one focuses with the dominant eye and brings the other eye into a unified picture only after focus has been achieved. When emphasizing counseling psychology in a relational interaction (overtly or covertly), I am able to pronounce godly wisdom over worldly. The Proverbs of the Old Testament are replete with the implications of this statement. Proverbs 12:15 (New International Version, 2011), for example, reeks of the consequences of finding wisdom alone. Counseling in a circumstance that is not friendly to biblical conversations and teaching in the same will require me to internally prioritize the understanding of where wisdom should come from while externally emphasizing how counseling psychology aligns with this view. I do believe counseling psychology aligns with the Bible's view of wisdom. I am starting to understand the language of psychology as an extension of and a different pronunciation of what the Bible has already said. 1 Timothy 3:16-17 (New International Version, 2011) corroborates (although typically I have a disdain for proof-texts) this conclusion. It states that Scripture is "useful... for every good work."

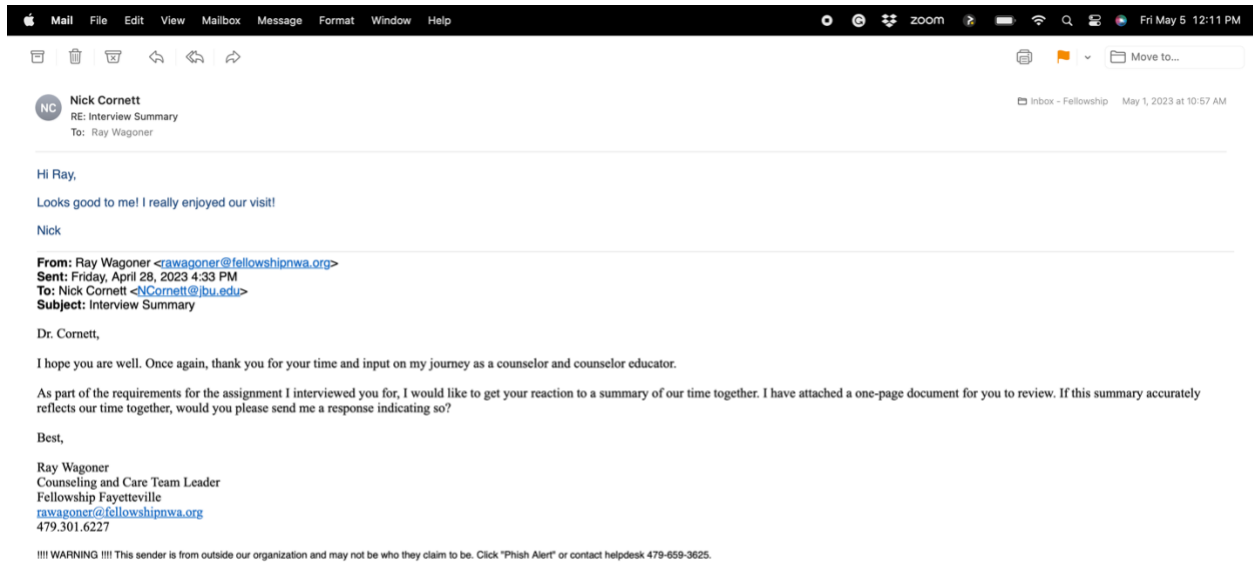
Finally, 2 Timothy 2:2 (New International Version, 2011) encourages the kind of discipleship and mentoring relationship that I wish to espouse in my educational endeavors. Not neglecting those who have gone before me, I want to hand off what I have been given and built upon to those who are coming after me. I cannot do this in good conscience without (at least internally) focusing on how my relationship to Christ and Christian Scripture has shaped my view of myself, others, and God (as my Higher Power). This assignment has cemented that understanding and desire for me. I can make my path my own and God is helping me forge it.

References

- New International Version Bible*. (2011). Zondervan. (Original work published 1978)
- Svinicki, M., McKeachie, W. (2014). *McKeachie's teaching tips: Strategies, research, and theory for college and university teachers* (14th ed.). Wadsworth, Inc.
- West, J., Bubenzer, D., Cox, J., & McGlothlin, J. M. (2013). *Teaching in counselor education: Engaging students in learning*. American Counseling Association.

Appendix A

Summary Approval



Appendix B

Interview Questions

1. How did you get started in counseling?
2. What led you to become a Counselor Educator?
3. How did you end up at your current institution?
4. What is important to you about being a CE?
5. What roles do you have that enjoy, and don't enjoy?
6. How does multicultural counseling shape your teaching style and curriculum?
7. In what ways do you like, or not like, being a mentor?
8. What concerns you or encourages you about the future?